Must Have, Would Like, Can Do

How to talk with your wife and your family before you compare care settings.

Your daughter says she can come by every day. Your wife says she wants her own kitchen. Both belong in the conversation, and both are worth writing down.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get onto one page what is essential, what she would like, and what each of you can realistically do. It isn't for choosing a place.

Who should be there

Your wife, first, if she's able to take part, even for a few minutes. Then the people who help her now or have offered to: the daughter who comes by, the son who phones on Sundays, the neighbor who sits with her on Thursday afternoons. Someone who can't be there can send a few lines ahead.

Ask one person to write things down, someone other than whoever is leading.

How to open

Start with her, and start with a question. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests a family meeting to discuss care needs, and says it is useful to think about your wife's own values and preferences about the kinds of help she will accept. [1]

- “We're not choosing a place today. We'd like to write down what matters to you, wherever you are.”
- “I've made a list of the help you get in a day. I'd like us to go through it together, and I'd like to hear what I've missed.”
- Say what the conversation is for: three lists. Say what it isn't for: picking a setting, or settling for good who does what.

Questions to ask

Ask your wife

1. What about the way you live now do you most want to keep?

2. Which kinds of help are you comfortable with, and from whom?

3. What would you want anyone who helps you to know about you?

Ask each other

1. Looking at the list of help she gets, which items would you call essential, and which are preferences?

2. What do you do for her now, and how much of it can you realistically keep doing? On which days, and for how long?

3. What can't you do, or can't keep doing?

4. Where do we see it differently from her, or from each other?

5. Which of these aren't ours to settle, and who on her care team do we take them to?

How to write down what was said

Keep three lists, and keep your wife's own words separate from the family's wishes for her. Where two of you see something differently, write both and leave it there. Anything medical, about her medications or about supervision goes on a separate line, as a question for her care team.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	MUST HAVE, WOULD LIKE OR CAN DO	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
“I want my own kitchen, even if all I make is toast.”	Your wife	Would like	
Someone beside her when she gets up from a chair.	You	Must have	
“I can come by every day after work.”	Your daughter	Can do	Your son asked about the weeks she travels

What not to decide yet

The first three take her care team's assessment, and the fourth doesn't need settling today. Your lists go with you as they are.

- What kind of care she needs.
- Which place, or which kind of place.
- Whether she can be on her own, or for how long.
- Whose view of the essentials wins.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the three lists and send them to everyone.
- Who will take each open question to her doctor, her nurse, her therapist, the social worker or your care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, choose a setting, or tell you what her care team will say. It gets your family onto one page, with her words on it and the differences left in.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked through what is essential, what your wife would like and what each of you can do. The care interview takes that further: it goes through every area of her daily life with you, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources